ThemeBot

BUSINESS PLAN · 1 OCTOBER 2026

How ThemeBot makes money

The short version on one page. Everything after this is a picture of why.

1

Sell a service now

We convert clients' websites to Shopify for a fee — and earn Shopify's referral cut on every store for 4 years.

2

Then sell the tool

SaaS with build credits for freelancers & studios. A licence for agencies that use their own AI account.

Don't mass-sell themes

Shopify's Theme Store rejects themes derived from Horizon or similar to others.

$12–20
AI cost per store after optimisation (today ~$45)

3–4×
more profit per agency when we sell credits vs. they bring their own AI

~$34k
monthly revenue by month 12 in our scenario ESTIMATE

Sources: two fact-checked research runs (each claim reviewed by 3 independent checkers), Anthropic / Shopify / OpenAI documentation, vendor pricing pages, and ThemeBot's own recorded AI usage. VERIFIED = fact-checked · ESTIMATE = our calculation.

OUR RECOMMENDATIONS

What we should do, in order

Eight actions. **NOW** = start immediately · **NEXT** = next 3–5 months · **LATER** = after the SaaS launches.

1 Prove it on one store first

Finish ECO ELI end-to-end with a passing match score; record real AI cost, fix rounds and hours. Nothing is sold before this.

NOW Impact: **unlocks everything** · weeks 0–2

2 Launch the done-for-you service

Convert clients' sites at ~$2,000 a store (far below agency rates). Register as a Shopify Partner and refer every store.

NOW Impact: **~$12k/mo + referral income** · from week 2

3 Add an ownership check

Customers confirm they own the site or have the rights to it. Get a short legal review of copying websites.

NOW Impact: **removes copyright risk** · before first client

4 Cut the AI cost per store

Sonnet 5.5 by default, cheap models for planning and summaries, overnight batch builds, a cost cap per build.

NEXT Impact: **$45 → ~$11–21** · weeks 4–10

5 Move the SaaS engine to Claude's API

Anthropic doesn't allow reselling Claude usage through Claude Code. Selling credits needs our own agent on the API (plus OpenRouter).

NEXT Impact: **makes credits legal** · weeks 4–10

6 Launch the agency licence

$3,995 once + $1,195/yr. Agencies use their own Claude login or API key through Claude Code — allowed today, zero AI cost for us.

NEXT Impact: **10 licences ≈ $40k yr 1** · weeks 8–14

7 Launch SaaS plans with credits

Freelancer $99, Studio $349, Agency $999. Cap builds and fix rounds; keep checks and previews free; top-ups at 2× cost.

NEXT Impact: **~$16k/mo by month 12** · weeks 12–20

8 List on the Shopify App Store

Billing through Shopify (0% on the first $1M). Keep Stripe for agencies on development stores. Apply to OpenAI's plan-sharing programme.

LATER Impact: **discovery + trust** · after week 20

✕ Don't do

Don't mass-produce themes for the Theme Store — Horizon-based or look-alike themes are rejected. At most 1–2 original themes on Skeleton, later.

Don't sell "unlimited" plans — AI cost makes them lose money (Replit, Windsurf, Cursor all had to switch to usage pricing).

Don't build our own "Sign in with Claude" or store customers' Claude logins — Anthropic forbids it.

Don't resell Claude usage while running Claude Code — credits only on our own API agent.

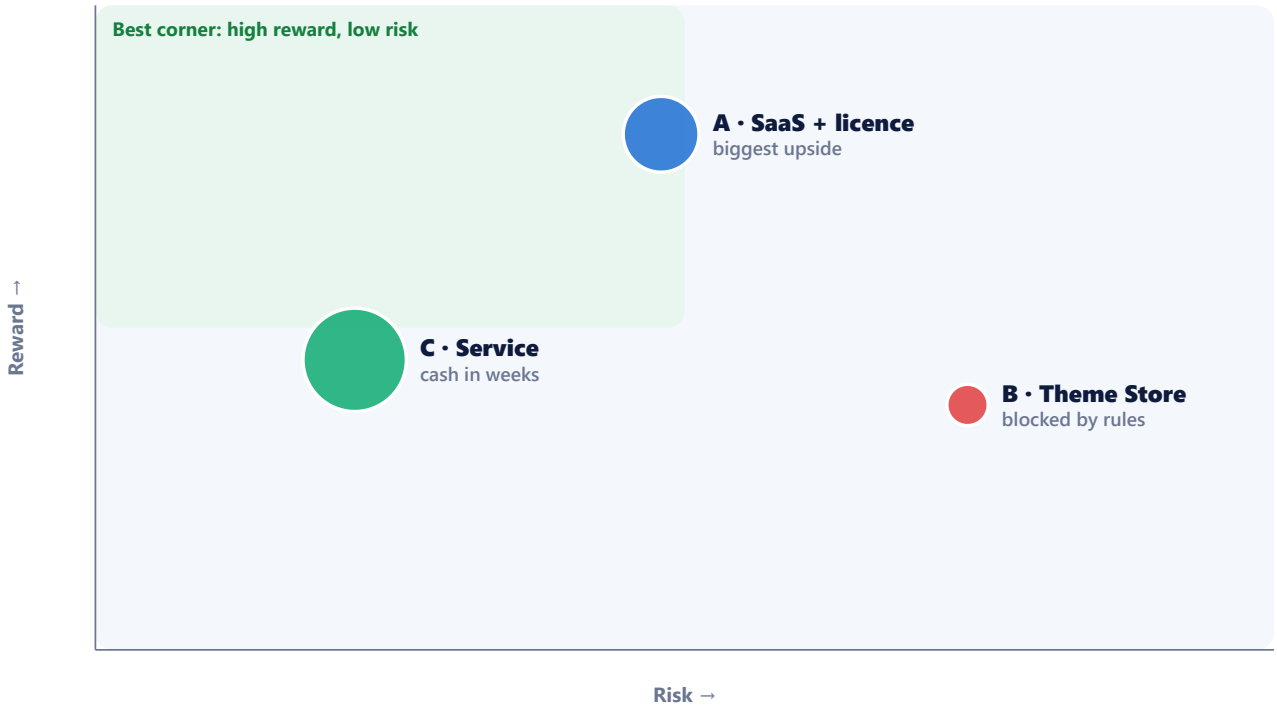
Don't price close to cost — every build and fix round at about 2× what it costs us.

Bottom line: earn now with the service, use that time to make the engine cheaper and legal for credits, then sell the tool two ways — credits for small teams, a licence for agencies.

1 · THREE WAYS TO MAKE MONEY

Which path wins

Reward vs. risk for each path. Bubble size = how soon it can make money.



START NOW

C · Service

Project fee + **20% of the store's Shopify fee + 0.1% of its sales for 4 years** VERIFIED

BUILD NEXT

A · Sell the tool

Credits must be metered — Replit's margin swung **+36% → −14%** on flat plans VERIFIED

SKIP

B · Theme Store

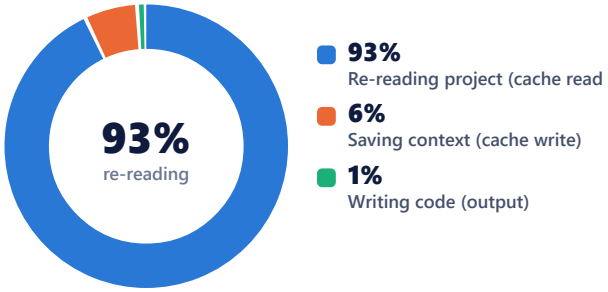
No Dawn/Horizon derivatives; each theme **fundamentally different**, even from your own VERIFIED

RECOMMENDATION Lead with the service (C), build the tool (A) on the same engine, and drop the Theme Store factory (B).

Where the AI money goes

What the AI spends tokens on

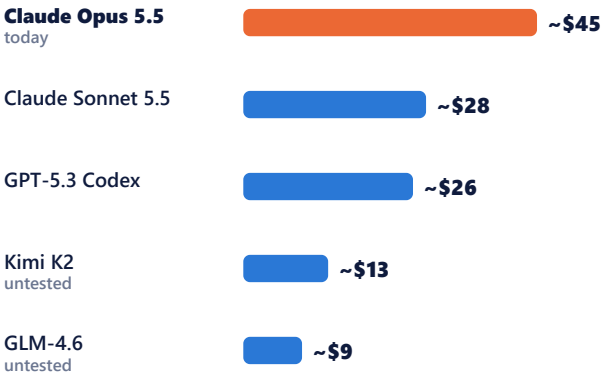
ECO ELI build sessions · 26.9M tokens



The AI mostly **re-reads the project** (cheap cached tokens). Writing code is only ~1%.

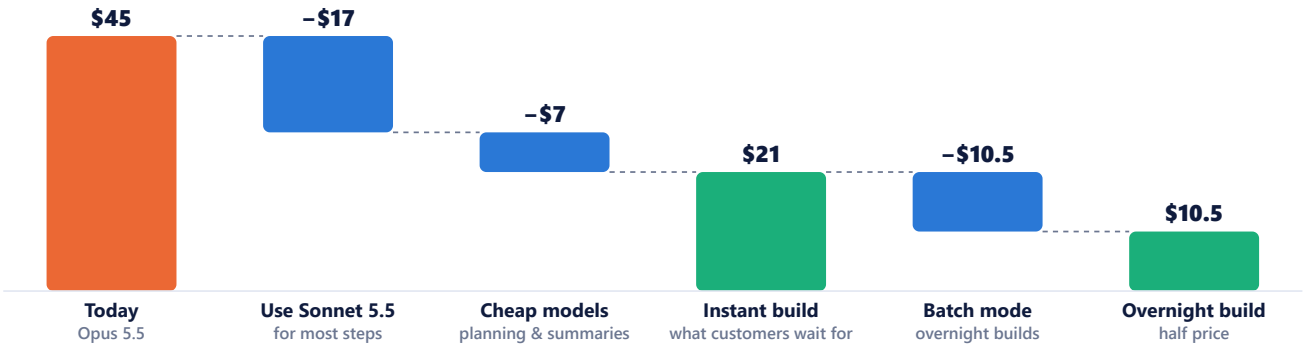
Cost per store by AI model

List prices · ESTIMATE · cheaper models untested



How we cut the cost: $45 → ~$21 instant, ~$11 overnight

Each step applied on top of the previous one ESTIMATE



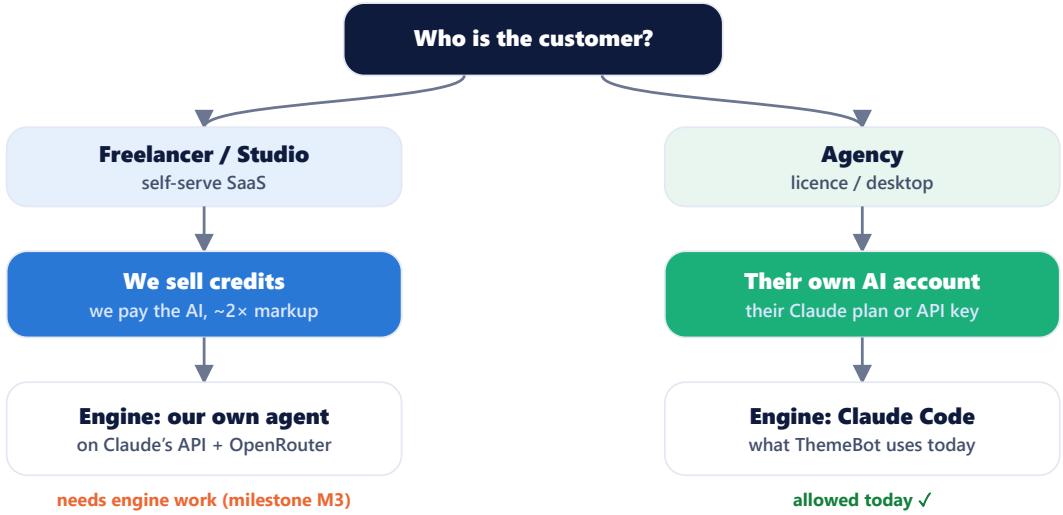
At a $149–199 price, **an 85–90% margin** — even when we pay for the AI.

RECOMMENDATION Make Sonnet 5.5 the default, route simple steps to cheap models, offer an overnight half-price build, and cap AI spend per build.

3 · WHO PAYS FOR THE AI

Credits, or their own AI account?

Anthropic's rules decide which engine each model needs **VERIFIED — Claude Code legal page**



Profit from one heavy agency

20 stores a month · **ESTIMATE**



The rules in one look

✓ Customer signs in to unmodified Claude Code with **their own** Claude plan or key

✓ We sell credits on **our own agent using Claude's API** (or OpenRouter)

✗ Our own "log in with Claude" screen or storing their login

✗ Reselling Claude usage while running Claude Code

! "Sign in with ChatGPT" plans: 16 approved partners only

RECOMMENDATION Small teams buy credits from us (needs our own Claude API agent); agencies bring their own Claude login or key through Claude Code.

4 · WHAT WE CHARGE

SaaS plans

Priced like Replo (closest Shopify tool: $99 / $499) and the 2× rule: a build costs us ~$15, so it sells for ~$80+. OUR PRICES

Free preview

$0

See the plan first

- Site analysis + quote
- Free visual check
- 14-day trial: 1 build

Freelancer

$99/mo

1 person

- 1 build / month
- 25 fix rounds
- No ThemeBot branding

Studio ★

$349/mo

Small team · 3 seats

- 3 builds / month
- 75 fix rounds
- Your brand on reports

Agency

$999/mo

10 seats

- 8 builds / month
- 200 fix rounds
- White-label, API, priority

$79–99
each extra build

~$1.25–1.50
per extra fix round (cost to us ~$0.70)

−17–20%
for yearly billing

What each plan caps

Cap what costs us money; give away what's free for us.

	Freelancer	Studio	Agency	
Builds / month	1	3	8	costs us money
Fix rounds	25	75	200	costs us money
Seats	1	3	10	stops account sharing
White-label	—	branding	full	first upgrade trigger
Checks & previews	∞	∞	∞	free for us → unlimited

RECOMMENDATION Launch Freelancer $99 / Studio $349 / Agency $999 with a card-required 14-day trial; push Studio as the main plan; keep checks free.

The agency licence

Agencies run ThemeBot themselves with their own AI account. However many stores they build, our AI cost stays $0.

Studio licence

$1,495 once

+ $495 / year for updates

- 2 seats
- Up to 10 client stores a year
- 12 months updates & support

Agency licence ★

$3,995 once

+ $1,195 / year for updates · or $1,995 / year

- 10 seats
- Unlimited client stores
- White-label + resale rights

Benchmarks VERIFIED: agency CMS licence $999 one-time (unlimited sites, resale); bring-your-own-key desktop AI app $39–$395.

SaaS vs. licence — who gets what

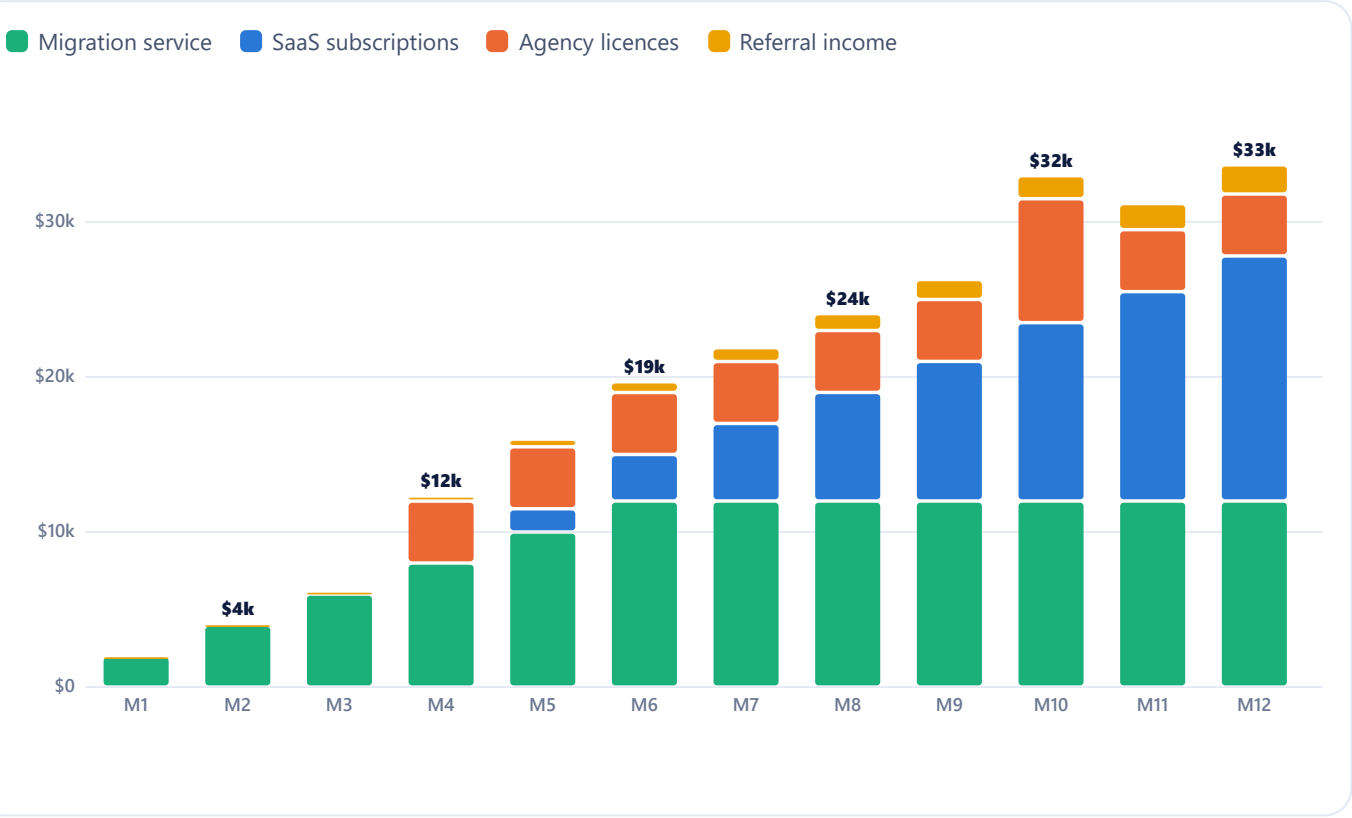
FEATURE	FREELANCER / STUDIO	SAAS AGENCY	AGENCY LICENCE
Builds, checks, live code, Rebuild	✓	✓	✓
Who pays for the AI	We do (credits)	We do (credits)	**Agency**
Builds per month	1–3	8 + top-ups	**Unlimited**
White-label reports / client portal	—	✓	✓
Resale rights	—	—	✓
Priority queue, API	—	✓	n/a
Runs on their machines, data stays local	—	—	✓

RECOMMENDATION Sell the Agency licence ($3,995 + $1,195/yr) to agencies that build a lot — their volume runs on their own AI bill.

6 · THE FIRST YEAR

How revenue could grow

Monthly revenue by stream. The service pays first; the SaaS takes over once launched. ESTIMATE



6 / mo
migrations at $2,000 (from month 6)

50
SaaS customers by month 12

10
agency licences in year one

57
stores earning us referral income

Market facts behind it

0%
Shopify's cut on the first $1M of app revenue (then 15%) VERIFIED

$16–30
entry price of every AI builder — all metered VERIFIED

~$394
referral income per store per year (example store) ESTIMATE

Not verified: Shopify store count (2.8–6.9M), agency build prices ($5k–40k). Refuted: Lovable's ~$500M ARR.

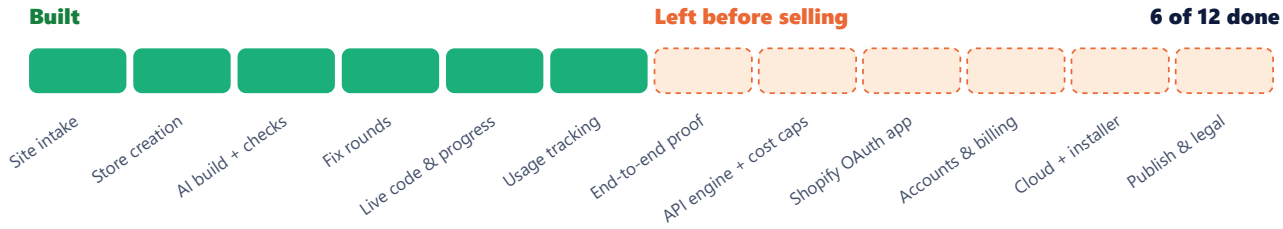
RECOMMENDATION Use the service income to fund the engine work; aim for 50 SaaS customers and 10 licences in year one.

7 · ROADMAP

What's built, what's next

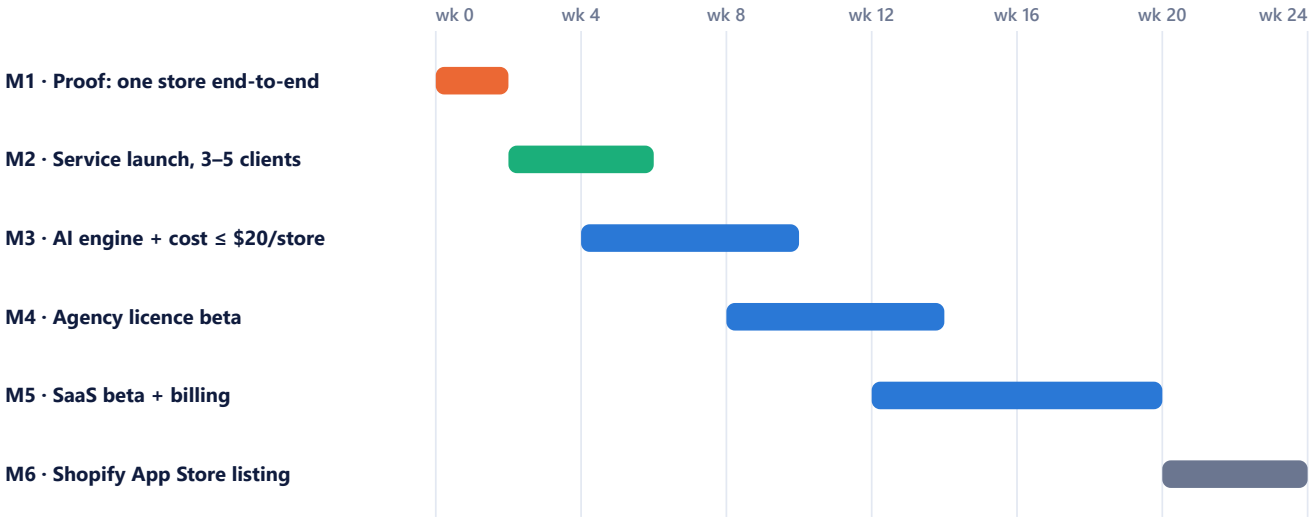
How ready is the product?

From our review of the app



Milestones · next 24 weeks

Each bar is one milestone; the service starts earning while the product is finished



Keep in sync

Theme updates when the source site changes — a monthly add-on

Multi-store dashboard

For agencies, with a client portal

A/B tests & CRO

What page builders charge extra for

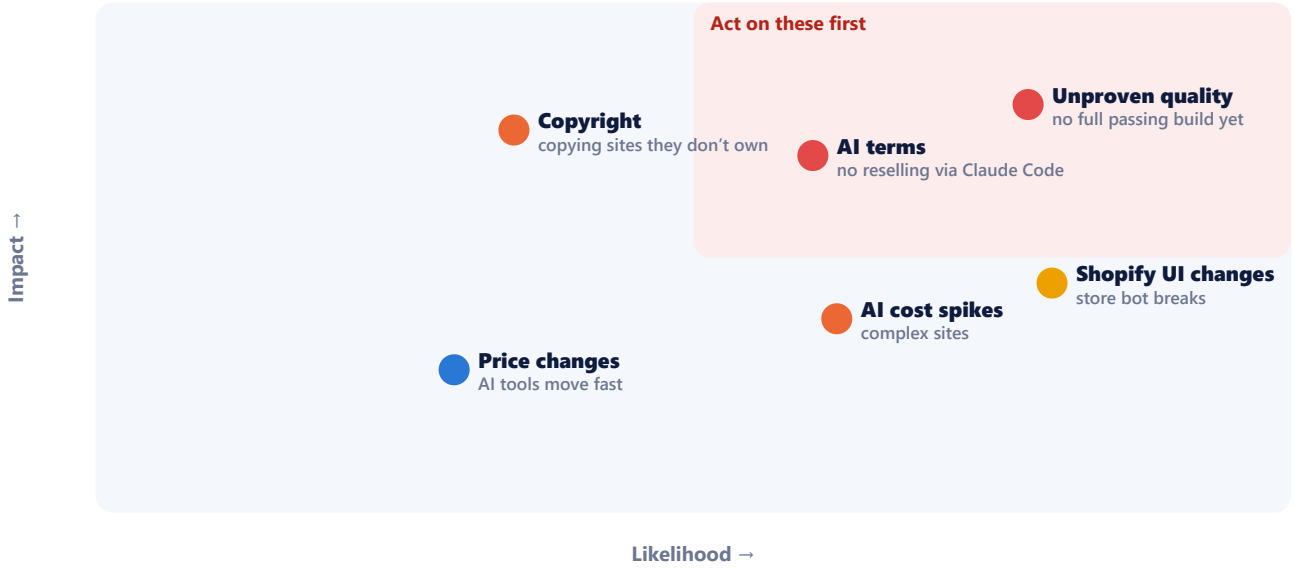
Original themes

Built on Skeleton — the only way into the Theme Store

RECOMMENDATION Do milestone M1 before anything else — every number in this report assumes a store can be finished end-to-end.

8 · RISKS

What could go wrong



First step before selling anything: finish one store end-to-end with a passing match score, and record its real cost and time.

Sources

Anthropic — Claude Code legal & compliance: code.claude.com/docs/en/legal-and-compliance

Anthropic model prices: Claude API reference (models table, 25 Sep 2026)

Shopify Theme Store requirements: shopify.dev/docs/storefronts/themes/store/requirements

Shopify Theme Store revenue share: shopify.dev/docs/storefronts/themes/store/revenue-share

Shopify App Store revenue share: shopify.dev/docs/apps/launch/distribution/revenue-share

Shopify app billing: shopify.dev/docs/apps/launch/billing

Shopify partner earning model: shopify.com/partners/blog/a-new-partner-earning-model

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Replit margins: sacra.com/c/replit · blog.replit.com/effort-based-pricing

AI coding margins: techcrunch.com/2025/08/07/the-high-costs-and-thin-margins-threatening-ai-coding-startups

AI builder pricing: productos.dev/blog/ai-app-builder-pricing-compared · lovable.dev · bolt.new · v0.app · replit.com

Replo: replo.app/pricing · docs.replo.app/getting-started/plans

Bessemer AI pricing playbook: bvp.com/atlas/the-ai-pricing-and-monetization-playbook

Licensing: unfoldcms.com/pricing · typingmind.com/buy · licensespring.com

OpenAI Sign in with ChatGPT: developers.openai.com/siwc/quickstart · thenewstack.io/sign-in-with-chatgpt

OpenRouter: glamdringresearch.com/post/openrouter-pricing · github.com/OpenRouterTeam/sign-in-with-openrouter

Model prices: pricepertoken.com (GPT-5.3 Codex) · dev.to/eagerspark (Kimi, GLM)

ThemeBot usage: shopify_works/.factory/usage.jsonl (27–28 Sep 2026)

Not legal or financial advice. Prices and terms change often — re-check before launch.